The NRC also opened up old discords in other north-eastern states. In November 2019, Meghalaya brought in an ordinance that virtually closed its borders with Assam, requiring all ‘outsiders’ staying more than twenty-four hours to register with the government.[175] In Tripura, indigenous tribes began demanding their own NRC in 2019 to expel Hindu Bengalis.[176] Many indigenous groups in these states were worried that the safeguards may not be enough. Their primary concern was a fear of engulfment by outsiders. Unlike in Assam, ‘outsiders’ in other states is not a dog-whistle for Muslim immigrants. In Tripura, by 2020, the immigrant Bengali population accounted for over 65 per cent of the state’s population. Even though there are laws to protect the interests of the local tribes, the state has only had Bengali chief ministers since 1977. In Meghalaya, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh, ‘outsiders’ denoted any settlers.

The BJP’s big challenge as it seeks to consolidate its gains in the Northeast is one of trust. In 2018, for example, its expansion effort in Mizoram also opened up old Bru–Mizo tribal rivalries. When the Election Commission sought to allow displaced Bru refugees located in relief camps in Tripura to vote in state assembly elections, Mizo groups protested. They feared that Bru groups backing the BJP were being illegally included in the electoral rolls. Such was the intensity of the opposition that the Election Commission had to remove Mizoram’s chief electoral officer, S.B. Shashank.[177]

By early 2021, the BJP, through a combination of strategies, organisational commitment, smart alliances and tactical flexibility had replaced the Congress as the primary national party in the Northeast. But this success also brought with it new kinds of challenges, reopened old legacy issues and brought into sharp focus the dissonance between the party’s driving impulses in the Hindi-speaking states and the demographic diversity in the eastern states. How the BJP negotiates these new tensions will be crucial for its own political future as well as for Indian democracy.